

VICTIMS OF violence

FIGHTING FEMICIDE

Male-perpetrated violence against women is a global and age-old crime. In ancient Rome a man could beat, divorce, or murder his wife if she threatened his honor or property rights, while English common law in the 18th century allowed a husband to beat his wife to maintain “family discipline,” as long as he used a stick no thicker than his thumb. In the 19th century early feminists sought marriage law reform, but it was not until 1871 that Alabama became the first US state to rescind the legal right of men to beat their families.

Seeking refuge

During the 1960s, and second-wave feminism (see pp. 272–275), women began to view their problems as the result of gender-based discrimination. These realizations spurred on the founding of women’s shelters, abuse hotlines, and rape crisis centers. In 1971, Erin Pizzey opened the first women’s refuge in the UK, and Anne Summers set up the first feminist women’s shelter in Australia in 1974.

A major development in taking violence against women seriously was the popularization of the term “femicide” in the 1970s. Although

first coined in 1801, femicide has been going on for centuries—from the burning of witches (see pp. 122–123) to female infanticide and “honor” killings. Femicide links the killing of girls or women to the violence they experience within patriarchal societies.

Typically, the most marginalized women are most vulnerable to violence. In the US and Brazil, for example, low-income transgender women of color are disproportionately at risk of femicide. Black and Latina women in the US and indigenous women in North America are disproportionately subjected to physical and sexual violence. For decades, activists in Canada have been protesting against the disappearance and murder of indigenous women, including along a stretch of British Columbia highway nicknamed the “Highway of Tears.” In 2010, Jaime Black, a Métis Canadian artist, created the REDress Project, an ongoing public art installation that hangs up red dresses in cities across Canada to mark the absence of missing and murdered women.

According to the United Nations, 14 of the 25 countries with the highest rates of femicide are in Latin America and the Caribbean.

Feminists are now fighting back. The #NiUnaMas (“Not One More”) movement that began in Mexico has spread to Argentina, Uruguay, Ecuador, Peru, Bolivia, Colombia, Chile, Venezuela, and Paraguay. More than a dozen Latin American countries have now passed laws against femicide, but there is still a long way to go to end violence against women worldwide.



**“WE WANTED TO
DO SOMETHING
ABOUT DOMESTIC
VIOLENCE.”**

ANNE SUMMERS ON THE CREATION OF HER FIRST WOMEN’S REFUGE, 2014